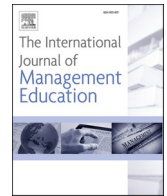




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How the “West as method” fails: A study of entrepreneurship education from the perspective of China

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ABSTRACT

China's entrepreneurship education has developed a unique model that positions entrepreneurship education as a critical means of talent cultivation, resulting in the “learning through competition” model. Entrepreneurship education in China, imported primarily from the United States, exhibits significant differences. Existing research has highlighted these disparities; however, there is a notable lack of in-depth, detailed descriptions and comprehensive analyses of their underlying causes. Employing qualitative research methods, this study examines how these differences are shaped from a Chinese perspective. It reveals how Chinese higher education perpetuates an Americentric canon within the social sciences, but fails to implement “the West as method” in entrepreneurship education. However, while China has adopted the external aspects of American entrepreneurship education—such as curricula, competitions, and mentorship—the internal logic of the Chinese system differs significantly, resulting in two distinct educational landscapes. Key factor contributing to the China-US differences include market maturity, deficiencies in Chinese comparative education, China's principles of equality rooted in its socialist ideology, the politicized nature of its education system, and a pervasive hustle culture. These elements have shaped China's entrepreneurship education goals, teacher cohorts, landscape and business plan competitions in ways that are distinct from those in the United States. By adopting an ‘Eastern as method’ perspective, this research enriches the discourse on entrepreneurship education and encourages deeper reflection on current practices.

1. Introduction

Entrepreneurship is a key force for sustainable development and competitive advantage (Birch, 1987; Ratten & Jones, 2020). Entrepreneurship education (EE) is increasingly viewed as a socioeconomic engine (Fayolle et al., 2016), and the demand for EE has grown rapidly worldwide (Gartner & Vesper, 1994). Under government promotion, EE has expanded globally (Fayolle et al., 2016; Katz, 2003; Pittaway & Cope, 2007). Since 2000, EE has been integrated into both elementary and higher education (Fayolle et al., 2016; Kyro, 2015). However, EE has advanced ahead of validating its theory, pedagogy and research (Fayolle et al., 2016).

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Current EE research is predominantly quantitative, resulting in an overemphasis on data (Sadowski, 2019). Much of this research explores relationships between factors influencing students' entrepreneurial intentions or behaviors, such as the perception of opportunity (Oakey et al., 2002), inspiration (Wang, Mundorf, & Salzarulo-McGuigan, 2021), passion and competency (Hou, Qi, Su, Wu, & Tang, 2023), and entrepreneurial self-efficacy (Amani, Ismail, Makona, Changelima, & Kazungu, 2024). The field is increasingly fragmented, with little known about actual practices and their accuracy (Naia et al., 2014; Fox et al., 2018). Quantification abstracts real targets into value systems, hindering novel views of uniqueness, diversity, and purpose, while creating false universalist tools to compare institutions and nations (Marginson, 2022). Given these deficiencies, EE lacks high-quality qualitative and comparative research. More empirical and comparative research on practices across institutions and contexts is needed to understand specific higher education contexts affecting entrepreneurial spirit (Pittaway & Cope, 2007).

The current American model, which emphasizes entrepreneurship, influences global trends in entrepreneurship education (Ratten & Usmanij, 2020). EE in the United States has evolved over 70 years. Myles Mace offered the first U.S. entrepreneurship course at Harvard Business School in 1947, marking EE's emergence (Katz, 2003). However, EE gained popularity in the 1980s when over 300 universities offered related courses (Kuratko, 2005). Growth accelerated in the 1990s as entrepreneurship courses, professorships, centers and publications doubled every 3–5 years (Katz, 2003). After 2000, business schools promoted EE across more fields such as engineering and arts (Katz, 2008). Vesper's studies show steady EE program growth, from 4 universities in 1968 to 504 by 2001 (Vesper & Gartner, 2001). By 2008, over 5000 U.S. colleges offered entrepreneurship courses (Kauffman Foundation, 2013). US EE has progressed through germination, development, and maturity. As a typical EE representative, the U.S. is an important emulation target for China (Li et al., 2017).

China's EE has a short history, emerging in the late 1980s after UNESCO's 1989 Beijing Conference (Li et al., 2017; Wang, 2015). Early EE practices were deeply influenced by UNESCO and the International Labour Office (ILO). In 2005, ILO and Chinese organizations promoted Know About Business, catalyzing EE development in China (China Youth Daily, 2008). The Ministry of Education (MOE) began emphasizing EE in 2010 (MOE, 2010). From then on, entrepreneurship education in China began to rapidly develop. During this period, Chinese higher education and comparative education communities started to emulate, adopt, and actively introduce American entrepreneurship education models. Chinese university administrators and professors, government delegations, and youth organizations were sent to the United States to study entrepreneurship practices and learn from the experiences of American universities, government institutions, and enterprises (Yu, 2018). In 2012, the MOE required all higher institutes to offer compulsory entrepreneurship courses for all students (MOE, 2012). It was also during this time that China emulated U.S. models, launching business plan contests, entrepreneurship tracks, courses, and incubators (Li et al., 2017).

Global capitalism's commodification of education drives rising knowledge demand and East-West convergence in certain learning forms (Han & Jarvis, 2020). As archetypal Western and Eastern representatives, the United States and China provide a comparative basis. With the United States leading globally in originating EE, China has actively learned US practices and begun nationwide promotion. Some previous studies have documented the differences between Chinese and American entrepreneurship education, and compared and analyzed the different educational models (Zhang, 2011), curriculum framework systems (Zhang, 2018), and ecosystems (Yu, 2018) of Chinese and American entrepreneurship education. Existing studies tend to introduce entrepreneurship education in China and the United States, summarize its development characteristics, and attribute the failure of Chinese entrepreneurship education to poor curriculum design, weak student entrepreneurial capabilities, insufficient faculty and mechanisms, and a weak environment (Liu & Bian, 2019; Song & Wang, 2011; Yang, 2016). These studies are mostly based on literature analysis and have not conducted a detailed and in-depth analysis of the differences in entrepreneurship education between China and the United States and the reasons for these differences, lacking scientific empirical research. Existing Chinese research on EE has largely adopted a comparative perspective, relying heavily on literature analysis, with a lack of detailed empirical studies. These studies often focus on Western models, particularly the market-driven approaches of the United States. In contrast, much of the Western research on EE has followed a quantitative paradigm, frequently using methods such as structural equation modeling and regression analysis to examine relationships between factors like entrepreneurial spirit, awareness, and behavior. This study moves beyond both of these dominant approaches by providing a deeper exploration of how EE evolves in different social contexts. It investigates often-overlooked factors that may shape these variations—factors that, while seemingly unrelated to EE, have significant impacts.

By examining the formation of China's unique 'learning through competition' model, this study introduces an 'Eastern as method' perspective to EE research. This approach—'promoting learning, teaching, and entrepreneurship through competitions' (以赛促学、以赛促教、以赛促创)—challenges the notion of a universal method for EE and adds diversity to the field. Furthermore, this perspective positions China's approach as a critical means of talent cultivation, highlighting the role of EE in developing skilled individuals essential for the nation's economic growth. While China's approach does not adhere to conventional market logic and faces practical challenges, it nonetheless enriches the diversity of global EE practices. This study aims to offer new perspectives for future research, suggesting that China's EE method, despite its imperfections, could provide a fresh direction for both research and practice in EE. This study aims to investigate the following questions: 1) What are the differences in EE between China and the United States? 2) How are these differences formed?

2. Colonialism, post-colonialism and comparative education in China

Social scientists and historians widely characterize the contemporary world as 'postcolonial', emphasizing colonialism's enduring imprint on the present global order (Edward, 2020). Post-colonialists acknowledge extant "hierarchies of knowledge", where one form is privileged over another, legitimized through power, and deployed differently across contexts (Hébert & Abdi, 2013, p. 9). The proliferation of Western ideologies in academia has spawned colonial science (Connell, 2009: ix) and colonial sociology (Poncelet,

2020). East-West asymmetries persist, with Western-centric epistemologies enabling ongoing western governance of knowledge and practice. Western knowledge constructs have engendered developing countries' dependence on the international political economy, including their university systems (Altbach, 1981).

Within postcolonial sociology, perspectives like "Southern theory" (Connell, 2009) and "Asia as method" (Chen, 2010) have emerged to counter western epistemological dominance and advocate for new worldviews. While the "postcolonial turn" or "Southern turn" has gained recognition across social sciences, comparative education (CE) still largely treats non-Western societies as sites for applying Northern theories rather than as independent producers of knowledge (Takayama, 2011).

Knowledge dissemination facilitates policy transfer, with the directional of knowledge flows being from the Global North to the Global South, alongside the spread of 'best practices' (Stone et al., 2020). From its inception, CE aimed to identify effective models for "borrowing" and improving schooling (Morris, 2015). While educational researchers and sociologists initially held sole responsibility as policy experts (Ball, 1998, p. 72), today, transnational agencies, consultancies, entrepreneurs, policymakers, and media are all increasingly involved in policy making (Ball, 2012; Morris, 2015). This pursuit of formulas for educational success and economic futures through performance relies on comparative expertise (Auld & Morris, 2014). Thus, CE is increasingly valued for its economic and political functions. The transnational community of mediating scholars, consultancies, and think tanks has become axiomatic for global policymakers, propagating knowledge claims and constituting a new research paradigm (Morris & Auld, 2012). Colonialism was inherent in the Western "civilizing mission", with CE being an indispensable part (Takayama et al., 2017, p. 13). Undeniably, international organizations' soft power now promotes the convergence of education systems worldwide (Bieber, 2016, p. 5).

In China, CE examines educational reforms and global education trends to inform policy making (Gu, 2018). Chinese CE mainly studies foreign macro-level systems and policies for transformative reference (Zhao & Gu, 1994) to advance national education (Chen, 2006: 7). As a policy advisory discipline, CE has gained academic status and influence in advancing development (Jia, 2023). Since reform and opening up, CE has penetrated Chinese educational research as a field and method, integrating with other disciplines to generate subfields like comparative higher education and vocational education (Han, 2013). Scholars observe China's tendency to reference Western countries, especially Germany and the United States, for educational policies and practices (Hayhoe, 1987; Tan, 2015).

China's CE demonstrates reliance on "the West as method" and immersion in "Northern theory", referencing major Western countries to emulate, imitate and "catch up" in modernization (Zhu & Wang, 2022). China has long followed an educational policy-borrowing model (Phillips & Ochs, 2003; Zhu & Wang, 2022). Though it creatively proposes a four-step transfer process of transnational influence, assistance, scientific escort and borrowing, this model exhibits simplistic linear thinking, mainly considering the unidirectional introduction by policy importers. It does not fully account for complex factors like the subjective status of exporters, policy variation in borrowing, and interaction with local contexts (Chen & Zhao & Gu, 1994; Zhu, 2021).

3. Superficially similar yet fundamentally divergent: EE in the United States and China

There are significant differences between Chinese and American EE in terms of curriculum, faculty, and entrepreneurship competitions. In the U.S., specialized entrepreneurship teachers emerged in the 1990s, with an increasing integration of teaching and research activities (Solomon & Fernald, 1991). In the 2000s, lecturers with entrepreneurial backgrounds began to dominate the educational landscape, and research findings were increasingly utilized in teaching (Fiet, 2001; Hägg & Gabrielsson, 2020). Moreover, American EE is uniquely supported by alumni entrepreneurs through private funding, including endowed chairs and donations (Pittaway, 2021). The first endowed chair in entrepreneurship was established in 1963 at Georgia State University, and by 2003, over 400 such positions existed in the U.S. (Katz, 2003). Importantly, these alumni also serve as advisors or mentors, actively engaging in university ecosystems and guiding student entrepreneurs (Zahra et al., 2011). In contrast, Chinese EE relies heavily on *fudaoyuan* (辅导员)¹ and non-entrepreneurial discipline teachers. A sizable community of researchers and instructors has emerged during the rapid expansion of EE in China, primarily from engineering (20%), management (16%), and education (10%) fields. The composition of Chinese university entrepreneurship instructors includes 35% *fudaoyuan*, 24% teachers in non-entrepreneurship disciplines, 16% specialized entrepreneurship teachers, and 13% external mentors (Huang & Huang, 2019).

Chinese students face significant challenges with the low quality of entrepreneurship course (Wang et al., 2022). The severe shortage of qualified faculty, combined with China's "imitative market-driven governance", where government planning predominates and market competition plays a limited role, has resulted in insufficient external impetus for EE development (Zhang & Zhang, 2018). To quickly meet government mandates, online and MOOC courses like *Introduction to Entrepreneurship* were introduced as remedies, used by most universities as general education courses to promote EE. However, the large scale of such courses has led to loose management, outdated content, and low engagement, failing to connect the course to entrepreneurial practice (Wang, 2021).

In the U.S., students learn entrepreneurship through competitions and have ample opportunities to pitch before investors. Competitions are a vital part of university EE, with numerous internal and open business plan competitions occurring across the country. These enable students to practice pitching and demos to investors and raise seed funding through prizes (Pittaway, 2021). In contrast, entrepreneurship competitions in China are predominantly organized by the government, with greater officialdom and larger scale. Chinese student entrepreneurship competitions are described by the Vice Minister of MOE as "phenomenal" global events (Wu, 2019).

¹ *Fudaoyuan* at Chinese universities are similar to academic advisors or counselors but have a broader range of responsibilities, including political and ideological education, moral education, academic advising, career guidance, psychological counseling, and supporting student welfare. *Fudaoyuan* in Chinese universities have a unique dual role, serving as both teachers and administrators.

These contests are embedded within China's intricate competitive system, forming a multi-level innovation and entrepreneurship competition hierarchy spanning universities, provinces and national levels (Wang, 2022). Additionally, Chinese contests incorporate designated political "red channels", seen as "a big lesson in ideological and political education" (Wu, 2019). The biggest difference from the U.S. is that American contests target new venture creation and spinoffs, with students participating out of entrepreneurial interest. In contrast, Chinese contests have broader objectives beyond incubation, with students often motivated by graduate school recommendations, GPA benefits, or career development (Wang, 2022).

4. Research methods

This study employed qualitative research method to gain an in-depth understanding of EE conducted in China and the United States, offering the flexibility needed for probing issues in depth (Denzin & Lincoln, 2018). The researcher served as the primary instrument for data collection, interpretation, and presentation (Creswell, 2009).

4.1. Research design

Following the cyclic model of qualitative research, this study involved iterative refinement of relationships between components rather than a linear approach (Miller & Crabtree, 1992; Chen, 2000). This study builds on the first author's re-examination of two EE studies in China and the U.S. (Wang, Mundorf, & Salzarulo-McGuigan, 2021; Wang et al., 2022), representing over a decade of observation. From 2016 to 2017, the first author conducted an empirical study of the entrepreneurship ecosystem at UCLA, involving semi-structured interviews with 33 students, mentors, organizers, and entrepreneurs (Wang, Mundorf, & Salzarulo-McGuigan, 2021). After benchmarking American EE, the author returned to China in 2018 for fieldwork, using maximum variation sampling to select 15 interviewees from four diverse universities in Zhejiang (Wang, 2022). These two rounds of research resulted in publications examining EE in China and the United States. However, the researcher was left with a lingering question: Why does China's entrepreneurship education, borrowed from the United States, differ so significantly? This study aims to explore this question from a Chinese perspective.

4.2. Site selection

The study was conducted in economically developed regions of China, focusing specifically on universities in these areas. Zhejiang Province, known as China's "Silicon Valley," was chosen as the study site due to its universities' leading role in EE (Mei & Symaco, 2022). Three universities with outstanding EE performance were selected for interview sampling. The first is a top comprehensive university in China, with alumni who have achieved significant success in entrepreneurship and have incubated numerous unicorn companies. The second university excels in teacher education and is the alma mater of a renowned Chinese entrepreneur. The third university is well-known in China for EE, and the city where it is located is considered the cradle of China's private economy and a haven for entrepreneurs.

4.3. Sampling strategies and data collection

This study draws on data collected primarily through semi-structured interviews with entrepreneurship mentors, university

Table 1
Participants' detailed information.

Description of Interviewees				Type
Code	Gender	Identity	Institute	
M1	Male	Dean	School of Entrepreneurship	Managers
M2	Male	Secretary	University Youth League Committee	
M3	Male	Director	Government	
M4	Male	Vice Minister	Government	
M5	Male	Secretary	University Youth League Committee	
M6	Female	Judge	Entrepreneurship competition	
M7	Male	Secretary	University Youth League Committee	
M8	Male	Director	University Innovation and Entrepreneurship Center	
M9	Male	Vice President	University	
Code	Gender	Identity	Area	
E1	Male	Mentor	Entrepreneurship Education	Experts or Mentors
E2	Male	Mentor	Entrepreneurship	
E3	Male	Expert	Higher education	
E4	Female	Expert	Comparative education	
E5	Female	Expert	Entrepreneurship Education	
E6	Male	Expert	Higher education	
E7	Male	Expert	Entrepreneurship Education	

managers, educational experts and entrepreneurs from March 2022 to December 2023. Two sampling strategies were utilized. First, opportunistic sampling, where the first author attended numerous EE conferences and events in China to identify potential respondents. Second, typical sampling was used to select three universities in Zhejiang Province known for excelling in EE. Third, stratified sampling ensured representation from all key stakeholder groups. Respondents were categorized into different strata—Tailored interview protocols were developed for each stakeholder group to address their specific experiences and perspectives. Tailored interview protocols were developed for each stakeholder group to address their specific experiences and perspectives. This approach allowed for capturing detailed and relevant information from each group, enhancing the richness of the data. Ultimately, 16 interviewees were obtained, including 2 government officials, 6 EE administrators, 1 entrepreneurship competition judge, 2 entrepreneurship mentors, and 5 education experts (see Table 1). Each interview lasted 20–50 min and was electronically recorded. The interviewer employed the ‘suspension’ method during the interviews to minimize researcher bias and ensure the validity and reliability of the data.

To triangulate the research, the first author supervised student participation in the ‘Challenge Cup’ National College Student Business Plan Competition and served as a *fudaoyuan* organizing A University’s ‘Challenge Cup’ contest in 2023, enabling immersive participatory observation. These observations were recorded as field notes.

4.4. Data analysis

This study primarily employed thematic analysis to interpret various aspects of the research topic (Braun & Clarke, 2006). First, we read the interview materials repeatedly to familiarize ourselves with the content. Second, we coded the data using an inductive method to generate initial codes. Third, we sorted and summarized all the codes, classifying them into different potential themes. Fourth, we continued interviewing based on the generated themes and constantly searched for new potential themes. When no new themes emerged, theoretical saturation was reached, and the interviews concluded. Fifth, we reviewed all themes, merging repeated themes and deleting those irrelevant to the research questions through continuous comparison. Sixth, we defined and named four important themes. All interviews and data analysis processes were completed by the first author to ensure internal consistency.

5. Finding

While both Chinese and American EE models aim to foster entrepreneurial skills, their underlying philosophies and approaches diverge significantly. In the U.S., EE is largely market-driven and operates through a bottom-up approach, encouraging individual entrepreneurial initiatives that are often supported by private funding and robust entrepreneurial ecosystems. American EE emphasizes real-world entrepreneurial success, with competitions, mentorship programs, and industry connections designed to help students launch viable businesses. In contrast, China’s EE operates within a top-down, government-led framework, with a primary focus on talent cultivation and broader socio-political objectives. While entrepreneurship contests and programs exist, they are often embedded within the nation’s educational and political structures, with goals extending beyond individual business creation to include political and ideological education.

A distinctive feature of Chinese EE is its alignment with government objectives. The goal is more focused on talent cultivation rather than direct business creation, which is reflected in the curriculum, often offered as general education. Many EE mentors, beyond just management teachers, have taken on the role of talent development. Additionally, while China adopted entrepreneurship competitions from the U.S., these competitions are integrated into the university evaluation system, with the primary objective shifting from business incubation to winning national competition grand prizes. This shift has led to a lower incubation rate in China’s EE competitions.

The disparities in political systems, market maturity, and cultural norms between the two countries have profoundly influenced the replication of EE frameworks. While the U.S. model emerged organically through private backing and entrepreneurial ecosystems,

Table 2
The Chinese EE model vs. the American EE model.

Dimensions	China	The United States
Philosophical foundations	Chinese EE is a top-down, government-led system focusing on talent cultivation and national economic goals	American EE is rooted in a market-driven, bottom-up approach where entrepreneurial success is tied to market responsiveness and innovation
Discipline of Origin	Comparative education and higher education	Economics and management science
Goals of EE	Talent cultivation	Start a business
Implementation strategies	Entrepreneurship is embedded in national contests and competitions but with broader political and educational goals	Encourages individual entrepreneurial initiatives through competitions and mentorship, often supported by private funding
Curriculum and Pedagogy	More aligned with government agendas, and many of the courses are offered as general education	More practical, market-focused, and supported by entrepreneurial ecosystems
Faculty	Specialized faculty and <i>Fudaoyuan</i>	Specialized faculty and external entrepreneurs/investors
Entrepreneurship competitions	Students have broader objectives beyond incubation, such as graduate school recommendations and GPA benefits	Target new venture creation and spinoffs
Effects	Chinese Model: Greater emphasis on education over actual business creation, potentially hindering real-world entrepreneurial outcomes	U.S. Model: Foster entrepreneurial innovation and direct business creation

China's EE system developed under significant state-driven impetus, following a campaign-style developmental path. As a result, China's approach, though successful in promoting entrepreneurship education at an institutional level, has struggled to achieve the same level of business creation and market responsiveness seen in the U.S. These differences suggest that China could benefit from integrating more market-driven elements into its EE framework while maintaining the government's role in talent development. This study offers an in-depth analysis of these differences, as summarized in [Table 2](#).

5.1. Research and policy together shaped EE, targeting all students

In the U.S., EE and related research emerged from business schools and spread to other fields, driven by market demands and academic developments. Conversely, Chinese EE was largely pioneered by CE scholars drawing on foreign models, rather than originating in economics and management science. Unlike the U.S., Chinese entrepreneurship research did not underpin educational developments. Initially, Chinese EE targeted graduate employability (MOE, 2010), but it evolved under shifting research and policy spotlights. Leading academics like Xiaozhou Xu proclaimed lifelong, global EE principles, informed by comparative scholarship ([Xu & Wang, 2016](#)). Others, like Zhanren Wang, advocated that EE should "target all students," "integrate with professional education," and "permeate the entire talent cultivation process" ([Wang, 2015](#)). Zhaoxin Huang contributed empirical insights and the concept of 'post-entrepreneurship', which emphasizes maintaining an innovative spirit and entrepreneurial drive within one's job to achieve career success ([Huang et al., 2012](#)). Research resonated with policies advocating integration of innovation and EE throughout talent cultivation (State Council, 2015), reflecting academic insights on permeating all curricula and students. Research and policy formed a coherent emphasis on broadly fostering students' innovation and enterprise, not just producing startups. This view was also confirmed by M4, a government official formerly in charge of China's EE, who mentioned:

"Our entrepreneurship and startup competitions have two orientations: one is innovation and the other is talent cultivation, so that talents can grow through entrepreneurship competitions, not necessarily to start their own business. Our entrepreneurship education should ultimately return to educating people, considering how to cultivate students' practical ability, innovative spirit, entrepreneurial awareness and entrepreneurial ability. In fact, entrepreneurial ability is essentially a practical ability, knowing when and what to do, not simply following a pure business model of entrepreneurship." (M4)

5.2. Comparative research on EE shaped the landscape of Chinese EE

Chinese CE researchers and comparative methodologies have profoundly informed national education policy making and implementation. Through research papers and reports, scholars advise governments and influence policy development and implementation by officials and leaders. In turn, policy uptake offered career incentives to academics via performance evaluations. In Chinese academic culture, outstanding scholarship traditionally enables official appointment (学而优则仕), differing from U.S. university administration. Chinese higher education administrators are often scholars promoted internally rather than professional managers. Academics with research adopted into policy and driving social progress can advance professionally. This represents a significant career path. During the formative period of China's EE, abundant literature, especially government reports, enabled Chinese scholars to undertake substantial research into Western countries, strengthening the launch of policies and development of China's EE.

However, many Chinese EE researchers applied comparative approaches uncritically. Their policy borrowing was often acritical, examining mainly government or international organization reports and directly transplanting foreign systems. E6, an expert in Chinese higher education, describes China as a testing ground for American theories:

"The price we pay for learning from the United States is to look at American theories as knowledge, and some Chinese scholars use Chinese students and universities to validate American theories, treating China as a testing ground. Many scholars in China, even when studying purely Chinese issues, prefer to find Western theories to support them, including innovative entrepreneurship education." (E6)

Though absorbing the external forms of Western education, the essential substance was often discarded. This paradigm lacked empirical study of China's realities, with foreign references and models adopted without adaptation and localization for China's EE. Consequently, Chinese EE policies and practices became sharply decoupled. This perspective was echoed by multiple interviewed experts, including E3, a prominent higher education scholar and editor-in-chief of an authoritative Chinese journal in higher education, who argued:

"I believe the paradigm of CE methodology has many flaws in China. The discourses in China diverge from the West. Without solid theoretical grounding in higher education itself, translation and borrowing will be inaccurate. Moreover, Chinese decision-makers, in their haste to learn about foreign contexts from experts, neglect establishing native Chinese higher education theory. The essence of China's education system (a blend of socialist principles and market-oriented reforms) is something that Western nations simply cannot possess. There, education is often viewed as a professional domain; as Dewey said, education has no aims beyond itself. China, on the contrary, integrates broader socio-political aims into its education system." (E3)

The Chinese government's policy making heavily relies on expert consultation and is eager to reference foreign practices, yet it lacks scientific, rigorous decision-making processes and evidence-based verification, as noted by E4, a CE expert:

“Our policy making processes are still insufficiently scientific, including the competencies of both CE researchers themselves and policymakers. The latter lack robust scientific cycles of evidence-based policy making.” (E4)

The Chinese government’s policy evidence is more focused on using policy approaches as justification, displaying a thoroughly technicized tendency in CE (Ball, 2006, p. 56) and an evidence-insensitive, non-ideological orientation (Ozga & Jones, 2006). The adherence to American EE models, combined with China’s centralized political system and nationwide education apparatus, led universities across China to replicate core American models like entrepreneurship curricula, student entrepreneurship parks, and incubators. As M3, director of a department of the MOE reported:

“The report presented to the national leaders should only present foreign practices concretely, without adding the researcher’s personal views and commentary. We just want to know what the current problems are and what should be done about them.” (M3)

This approach aligns with the “thoroughly technicized tendency of comparative education” (Ball, 2006, p. 56) and the perception of “evidence-based, non-ideological accounts” (Ozga & Jones, 2006). This technicized tendency of Chinese EE has impacted policy-makers’ decisions, which lacked theoretical and methodological foundations, and neglected China’s broader cultural, social, and institutional contexts.

5.3. The political nature of EE shaped the distinctive faculty structure within Chinese universities

Fudaoyuan, a unique group of faculty members, were originally established to enhance the ideological and political education of students (State Council, 1986; Wang & Huang, 2012). Following the reform and opening-up period, the responsibilities of *fudaoyuan*’s expanded beyond political education to encompass a balanced distribution of educational, managerial, and service roles (Chen & Wang, 2021). Today, *fudaoyuan* represent a vital segment the faculty and management in higher education, embodying both teaching and administrative identities (Yang, 2011). Their duties include guiding students’ ideals, beliefs, and moral character; overseeing financial aid, employment, and stability maintenance; and organizing classes and party branches (Wang & Huang, 2012).

Although EE began to attract attention in 1989, it was historically overlooked by the Chinese government. During a prolonged period of unregulated exploration, international organizations played a pivotal role in its development and had a partial influence on the faculty structure that emerged later. In 2005, to promote entrepreneurship and employment among university students, the Communist Youth League Central Committee, the All-China Youth Federation, and the International Labour Organization jointly launched the Know About Business (KAB) EE project in China (China Youth Daily, 2008).

This initiative led to the cultivation of numerous EE instructors. Initially introduced to address employment concerns, *fudaoyuan* and administrative staff responsible for student employment became a significant group trained in entrepreneurship instruction through the KAB project. Consequently, the responsibility for delivering EE largely fell to *fudaoyuan*. E2, a senior researcher in social entrepreneurship studies, noted:

“Over a decade ago, when we first introduced the International Labour Organization’s KAB entrepreneurship teacher training programme at University B, many outstanding students in the class have since been promoted to deputy division head and division head positions! This highlights that EE can also enhance the career of relevant administrative staff, such as *fudaoyuan*.” (E2)

Furthermore, Chinese EE is closely intertwined with innovation, often referred to as “innovation and entrepreneurship education”. The courses, policies and activities associated with this approach emphasize innovation as a means of promoting scientific nationalism through higher education since China’s reform and opening-up period (Tin & Pan, 2021), particularly in response to U.S. technological containment in the educational sphere. Consequently, EE has assumed significant political purposes and national missions. The responsibility of *fudaoyuan*s for students’ ideological and moral education further reinforces their role in EE. With the widespread adoption of the concept of EE for all, its integration into talent cultivation has continually strengthened its political attribute. Notably, in 2019, MOE proposed a closer alignment of innovation and EE with ideological, political, professional, physical, aesthetic and labour education to enhance students’ competencies. As a result, innovation and EE have evolved into a comprehensive form of education.

5.4. The hustle culture shapes the utilitarian nature of Chinese university student entrepreneurship competitions

Research shows Chinese competitions exhibit inefficient incubation and packaging and exaggeration of entries (Wang, 2022). This situation arises because competition outcomes are tied to university discipline assessments and evaluations under the “Double First-Class” initiatives. Given that competitions serve as a critical metric for talent cultivation, faculty can enhance their performance and promotional prospects by mentoring award-winning students. In some lower-tier universities, where publishing opportunities are limited, national gold awards become crucial for faculty tenure. Even when not formally required for tenure, participation in competitions offers implicit benefits, as M7, secretary of a university’s Youth League Committee, noted:

“Candidates applying for *National Science Foundation for Distinguished Young Scholars* often spend tens of thousands of RMB from their research funds to enable students to participate in innovation and entrepreneurship competitions and secure national gold awards. The primary motivation is that, under similar conditions and comparable research capabilities, winning gold awards in entrepreneurship competitions provides applicants with a distinct advantage.” (M7)

Chinese students are incentivized to participate in entrepreneurship competitions through the offer of additional GPA points and credits, which can enhance their college applications, or improve job prospects, rather than to actually start a business (Wang et al., 2022). This emphasis on evaluation has altered the nature of entrepreneurship competitions in China, shifting the focus from entrepreneurship itself to winning national awards. M1, dean of a university's Entrepreneurship School, remarked on this phenomenon:

"China's colleges and universities are producing many pseudo-entrepreneurs who are primarily interested in startup competitions. This issue is not confined to local Chinese universities; it also occurs in top institutions such as Zhejiang University. While there are some genuine entrepreneurs within our university's entrepreneurship park, their numbers are quite limited. Most projects in university startup parks are still primarily designed for competitions." (M1)

Moreover, China's Confucian culture has long emphasized the dignity of teaching, resulting in a teacher-dominated relationship. Despite the introduction of student-centered educational ideas from the West over the years, effective implementation remains insufficient (Tan, 2015). Teaching often overemphasizes the role of teachers and classrooms, while practical activities like entrepreneurship require immersive environments that are lacking in both Chinese classrooms and extracurricular contexts. This creates a disconnect between formal and informal EE. As E5, a EE expert, suggested:

"Chinese EE lacks developing of students' metacognitive abilities and fails to present adequate challenges and learning. It resembles elementary education—very lively, but after this liveliness, it may lack more immersive talent cultivation." (E5)

As expressed in the ancient saying, "the people's livelihood relies on diligence, diligence prevents collapse" (民生在勤, 勤则不匮), diligence has been a traditional Chinese virtue esteemed since ancient times and is ingrained in the cultural DNA of the Chinese people. While diligence is a strength, the rapid pursuit of goals it fosters has also led to pragmatism and a pervasive "hustle culture" in modern China. This hustle culture, characterized by constant self-driven efforts to work harder and faster, has facilitated China's remarkable development but has profoundly shaped society and talent cultivation into one characterized by high competition and "involution" (内卷). Initiatives such as the Double First-Class plan and metrics like academic assessments reflect China's anxiety about catching up with the West. This anxiety and involution filter down to Generation Z students, manifesting in their collective utilitarian mindset. This aligns with the author's survey on Gen Z values, which highlights a "pursuit of usefulness, strong personalization, experiential rewards, gaming, low self-expression, broad but fragmented knowledge, and a strong goal-oriented and pragmatic approach."

The instrumental and goal-oriented nature of Chinese education is evident in the overemphasis on classroom activities and narrow contests for evaluations and awards within universities. In the absence of performance evaluation and prizes, students often lack motivation to engage in entrepreneurship initiatives. This rigid focus on educational outcomes has negatively impacted the development of Chinese EE. As E7, a renowned EE expert, expressed concern:

"Students participate in these competition activities primarily to win awards. The allure of prizes can overstimulates students, ultimately hindering their development. Currently, our pursuit of freedom or engagement in seemingly purposeless activities has diminished. This reflects a characteristic of our country and highlights areas where we are particularly effective; however, this effectiveness also has its drawbacks." (E7)

6. Discussion

This research offers a unique perspective by discussing how Chinese higher education continues to perpetuate Americentric norms within the social sciences while failing to fully implement the "West as method" approach in EE. This study moves beyond examining micro-factors such as entrepreneurial awareness, teaching methods, and other aspects that lead to inefficiencies in EE (Janowski & Szczepańska-Przekota, 2024). It explores the impact of macro-factors such as politics, culture, and research on entrepreneurship education. Through qualitative methods, it deeply analyzes the differences between Chinese and American EE and elucidates the underlying causes of these disparities from a Chinese perspective.

In China, EE is fundamentally an imported Western concept and methodology. Chinese academicians, policymakers and practitioners in the EE sphere have unwittingly embraced Western policies, paradigms and approaches. The initial intent was to advance China's EE by emulating the United States. In practice, although China has adopted the "veneer" of American EE, with seemingly identical curricula, contests and business mentors, the internal logic vastly differs, resulting in two entirely divergent EE landscapes. Western countries employ a "bottom-up" EE approach, with universities vigorously soliciting funding and providing entrepreneurial programs based on individual needs. Conversely, China uses a "top-down", government-led and -funded approach (Liu et al., 2020; Yu, 2018). While market maturity is a key factor in the China-U.S. differences, this paper primarily contributes by probing the impacts on Chinese EE from policies, academic research particularly in CE, political systems, and culture, which has been inadequately explored.

Chinese research and policy jointly shape EE as general education targeting all students, diverging from U.S. objectives. In China, principles of equality, rooted in its socialist ideology, demand comprehensive parity across politics, economy, and society (Wu, 2015, p. 2). These principles provide ideological foundations for universal EE. However, in adopting American EE concepts and practices in China faces adaptability issues due to differing developmental environments. Specifically, the market economy underpinning the American system clashes with China's relatively government-led conditions. This institutional logic discrepancy means that directly applying unlocalized American models struggles to achieve desired educational outcomes in China. Thus, mimicking the exterior rather than the interior of American EE is unlikely to fulfill China's aims in developing its own EE system.

The reformist ideology dominating CE discourse reflects the adoption of external policies, models, practices and innovations to enhance national education systems (Wilson, 1994:453). This comparative analysis, rather than critical questioning, typifies modern

Chinese CE methodology. Although ostensibly pragmatic, this approach may unconsciously import unexamined epistemological biases and external borrowing, overlooking the interrogation of ideological aims. This research expands on Brehm's (2023) view of CE as a political project that supports dominant political and economic structures underpinning global capitalism while also influencing politics and reproducing mainstream capitalist education structures through consultancy and research. Unfortunately, many Chinese researchers have failed to recognize this, instead blindly drawing on American paradigms, norms, and approaches to EE without critical awareness.

As a qualitatively-oriented, humanities-inclined social science (Kazamias, 2009), CE requires interpreting educational data through national value systems (Holmes, 1965, p. 16). Chinese academics have acted as policy ambassadors, identifying international EE policy entrepreneurs and shaping Chinese EE discourse. However, flaws in their CE paradigm—non-rationality, unscientific borrowing, and technicist reliance on foreign evidence by policymakers—have caused maladaptation of imported EE models. Despite mimicking formal features, invisible factors like markets and culture cannot be copied, distorting EE development. CE must move beyond simplistic 'what works' identification to challenge facile answers and construct nuanced alternatives (Morris, 2015). Studying EE requires situating it within the broader knowledge and conditions shaping CE (Auld & Morris, 2014).

As Parmar (2012:10) notes, intellectuals foster their social group's economic, political and social consciousness and conceptualizations of society, as well as consolidating class positions. Chinese EE intellectuals have thus shaped this grouping and class formation. In conducting comparative research, Chinese academia has generated and legitimized EE discourses. Early scholars became university leaders through EE achievements, gaining power to promote policies like entrepreneurship competitions. This engendered EE institutional accumulation. During this process, vested interests formed and maintained the system. Even as EE policies and practices decoupled, these vested interests persisted with established approaches due to path dependence and inertia.

Chinese CE prioritizes government reports that are largely overlooked in international research, further entrenching the policy making trajectory of EE. However, the EE approaches showcased by international organizations, though providing references for China, pose significant risks. For example, the OECD links education to economics through discourse economization, primarily furnishing skilled labour for the knowledge economy while disregarding pedagogy and creativity (Ydesen, 2019). This perspective dangerously influences Chinese EE development. As Han and Jarvis (2020) indicate, Western dominance has influenced Eastern pedagogy, leading to the uncritical adoption of Western assumptions. Policymakers have not fully considered the ecosystem and infrastructure necessitated by Chinese university EE development. Large-scale EE promotion without proper adaptation and calibration has resulted in difficulties and irregularities.

Despite multiple shortcomings, China's EE has developed a unique approach, viewing EE as a means of talent cultivation, which has been implemented on a large scale across the country. However, China lacks the foundational infrastructure and ecosystem necessary for large-scale implementation of EE. The development of EE in China should be gradual and phased, with an initial focus on economically developed regions. This step-by-step introduction and progressive expansion can ensure a more effective and sustainable approach. Furthermore, China lacks indigenous theories and research tailored to its specific context. Simple borrowing from other countries is no longer suitable for the future of Chinese EE. Future development of EE in China should emphasize building a locally relevant theoretical foundation through more local research and theoretical discussions, thereby ensuring a seamless integration of theory and practice. The findings of this study further suggest that a context-sensitive approach is key to improve EE in China. Policymakers could prioritize localized curriculum design, adapting EE programs to China's unique socio-political and economic landscape by incorporating elements such as local market conditions and the role of government in entrepreneurship. Additionally, revising university evaluation metrics to reward entrepreneurial thinking and innovation—rather than focusing solely on academic achievements—would encourage universities to emphasize practical outcomes. Strengthening industry partnerships between universities and local businesses would provide students with real-world entrepreneurial experience suited to China's economic environment. Finally, in recognizing the complexities of the Chinese education system, it is crucial to address the significant regional differences that exist across the country. Economic development, cultural attitudes, and educational policies can vary widely between provinces, which in turn affects the implementation and effectiveness of entrepreneurship education. For instance, economically developed regions such as Zhejiang and Guangdong typically have more established entrepreneurial ecosystems, providing students with greater access to resources, mentorship, and opportunities for real-world engagement. In contrast, less developed areas may face challenges related to funding, infrastructure, and cultural attitudes towards entrepreneurship, which can limit the impact of EE initiatives. Therefore, allowing for regional differences in EE implementation, by tailoring strategies to the specific economic conditions of each region, would promote a phased and more effective development of EE across the country.

7. Conclusion

This study outlines Chinese higher education's perpetuation of the Americentric knowledge canon in social sciences, along with its failure to implement 'the West as method' in EE. While Chinese CE replicated American models, political, economic and cultural institutions resisted, resulting in the method's failure without positively impacting development. The reflection on 'the West as method' echoes calls to eschew social science's colonial complicity (Takayama et al., 2015) without proposing Eastern alternatives that equally emphasize one perspective. Such binaries impede the exploration of processes enabling the genuine globalization and democratization of knowledge production (Takayama et al., 2015). This study highlights the need for CE research to holistically reflect on the current education landscape through a more globally inclusive viewpoint (Silova et al., 2017). Future research should respond to the call for a comprehensive study of EE that considers changes in localized environments, such as the digital economy and the experience of casual labor (Ratten & Usmanij, 2020). Moreover, EE should be studied, borrowed, and implemented with consideration of macro-level political, cultural, and other institutional environments. The limitations of this study lie in its use of qualitative

research, which typically involves in-depth analysis with a small sample size, potentially limiting the generalizability of the findings. However, this approach also allows for a deeper, more interpretative understanding of the research questions, rather than the surface-level insights often provided by quantitative research. Future research should aim to expand the scope to identify more heterogeneity and additional factors influencing the development of EE in China.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Xuyan Wang: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Visualization, Validation, Supervision, Software, Resources, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Funding acquisition, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Shuhua Liu:** Supervision. **Lingli Zhang:** Data curation.

Submission declaration and verification

This article is not under consideration for publication elsewhere. No conflict of interest exists in the submission of this manuscript, and this manuscript is approved by all authors for publication. If accepted, this article will not be published elsewhere in the same form, in English or in any other language, including electronically without the written consent of the copyright-holder.

Ethical statements

No ethical issues were addressed in this paper, as we did not study any human or animal subjects, nor did we collect any personal information or sensitive data. Our study only involves interviews with interviewees. Before we started the interviews, we invited the respondents to participate in our research project, we told the respondents about the purpose of our research, and the respondents also be told that we would not disclose any personal information about the respondents and we would anonymize the respondents' information during the dissertation writing process. Interviews were conducted with the consent of the interviewees. The names of the interviewees and the organizations to which they belonged were anonymized during the writing of the paper.

Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare that there is no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

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Data availability

Data will be made available on request.

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